

The Elements of Story

When designing a chronicle, it's important to build good characters and recognize the underlying structure — scenes, chapters, stories, etc. — but those aren't the only factors involved. These elements help determine the shape of the events in a chronicle, and so are worth careful consideration before play begins.

Scale

Broadly speaking, scale refers to the breadth of the chronicle — how many different people and places will be involved. A game with a small scale might focus on a single motley in a modest town, with a relatively small cast of supporting characters and not much travel outside of town (and perhaps the local Near Dreaming). Other people and places might be mentioned, or perhaps handled in brief interludes, but generally the action stays focused on the central town.

A game with a larger scale, by contrast, features many more characters or locations, perhaps both. A chronicle about the cross-country tour of a motley of Kithain rock stars might feature dozens of locations as the characters roll from one town to the next, while a political thriller might not move as much but could feature a cast of dozens as the players navigate a complex web of intrigue and ever-shifting alliances.

The main difference in handling scale is the amount of preparation required — a game with a large scale is going to demand a high level of preparation, as well as good record keeping to make sure key locations are mapped out and important names aren't forgotten. Of course, the players can help with keeping notes once something is in play, but in general a large-scale game is going to take a fair amount of preparation in order to bring so many different elements to life in vivid and distinct fashion.

By contrast, a smaller-scale game requires fewer elements to prepare, though in turn it demands them to be fleshed out in a bit more depth or the players will run into gaps and blank spots. If the whole action of the game is set to take place in a single small town, it's not necessary to map out every house and street, but the players are likely to get fairly in-depth with important local people and places, so it's best to make sure key areas get good coverage to avoid running into problems.

Scope

If scale determines the size of the chronicle's cast and range of locations, scope determines the reach of the actions in the game, and what kind of consequences are entailed if the characters fail — or if they succeed. A game with a grand scope might involve stories where the fates of cities, nations, or even worlds are at stake, while a chronicle with a smaller scope might only affect the town where the characters live, or even just their own personal lives.

As with scale, nothing is wrong with keeping things on a personal scope; in fact, if the characters save the world every week, the players will quickly become inured to that level of

danger. Varying the scope of different stories thus allows for some contrast, not to mention breathing room, allowing the players to appreciate problems both large and small. Indeed, it's very possible that over the course of a chronicle stories will have different scopes, as many stories start with smaller events and then build to a larger climax.

For example, the chronicle might start off with the story of solving a single kidnapping, which in turn leads to another story centered on breaking up the whole kidnapping ring, and finally a story where the characters track down the villainous, Bedlam-crazed mastermind in his lair in the depths of the Dreaming. What began as a small, personal story slowly expanded into one that literally spanned worlds, all as the result of a naturally-escalating scope during the chronicle.

As with other story elements, it can be very useful to discuss the concept of an upper limit for the scope of the game (if any) when building a chronicle. If some players are expecting a lot of personal stories about their characters' daily lives, while others are expecting to run around saving whole cities from dastardly villains, there's going to be some disconnect and frustration in the group.

Stakes

Scope and scale are both necessary concepts, but stakes are what keep players invested and, in turn, what make dramatic events in the game really hit home emotionally. Simply put, stakes are what's at risk in a story, and therefore what motivates the characters to get involved. Figuring out what stakes are involved is important, not in the least because many stories involve characters getting into fights, investigating mysterious events, traveling to dangerous places, or breaking laws (fae or human), and nobody does those sorts of things without suitably-compelling reasons!

One of the most common stakes in roleplaying is putting lives on the line, typically either in a situation where the characters must defeat a villain before she kills them, or where the characters must stop a villain from killing innocents. Putting lives in the balance can make for a very dramatic situation, of course, but it's easy to fall into a trap of making that the most common set of stakes in a game and, like constantly setting the scope too high, stakes that are used too often become less effective, even dull.

Remember those superhero cartoons where the sidekick was *always* getting captured and threatened with some dire peril, and how little you cared about it after a while, maybe even joked about it? That's the danger with always using the same stakes. Fortunately, it's relatively easy to avoid falling into that sort of trap if the stakes "reset" from time to time, going from larger to more personal before ramping up again.

After defeating a deadly Thallain menace in a harrowing battle at the edge of town, for example, the characters might come home to find their mortal lives in disarray due to their need to blow off work, school, and family obligations to combat the supernatural threat. It might seem like a strange juxtaposition at first, but then again, battling Thallain rarely pays the rent,